to do was watch his thumb. One day, we were practising at the SSC Ground in Colombo when Murali came to the ground. Bhajji decided to go up and ask him how to bowl the doosra. Murali told Bhajji to use his thumb to support the ball from the top – that was the secret. I had no idea about this conversation until Bhajji told me later. I felt very gratified that I had worked it out for myself.

Being able to spot the doosra helped me a lot, and not just when I was batting. When I did an over of commentary during the final of the IPL in May 2013, I said on air that Bhajji had just bowled a doosra to dismiss the South African fast bowler Chris Morris. Morris had played for conventional off-spin when the ball had actually gone the other way. The commentators, including Harsha Bhogle on air, said they were impressed because they had not been able to pick the doosra and the replay had not yet been shown.

I should also say here that there were other occasions when I found it difficult to figure out what a bowler was planning to do. One bowler I found particularly challenging in this respect when I first faced him was the New Zealand fast-medium bowler Dion Nash. His action was such that I thought he would bowl inswingers at me, which he never did. I got out to Nash on the flattest of decks because I played for the inswinger when the ball was actually an outswinger. Eventually I worked him out, and even got a hundred against him in Wellington, but it did take me a while to do so.

Another bowler I had great difficulty picking at first was the West Indian left-arm fast bowler Pedro Collins. I had first seen Collins in a practice match during our May–June 2002 tour of the West Indies, when he bowled our opening batsman Wasim Jaffer with a big inswinger. I made a note that here was a bowler who started with inswing early on. Accordingly, in the next few innings I played for this inswing, only to see the ball leaving me and I ended up nicking deliveries behind the wicket. I was out to him three times and didn’t last more than two or three balls in each of these innings. Midway through the series, I spoke with a number of West Indies players and I was told that actually Collins hardly ever bowled inswing – he normally got the ball to angle away from the right-hander. So by the time of the final Test in Jamaica I was more confident against him and I managed to score 86.

The best bit about dealing with Collins, however, happened in India when the West Indies visited in November 2002. By then I had fully